Initially, after joining JPP, I stayed in a sort of hostel run by Ms Dixit. I say 'sort of' because it was basically one floor of a house. All the younger kids would sleep on the floor, in one hall that had a raised platform at one end, which became a bed once all the mattresses were taken down. Above the kitchen was a small loft with a wooden pallet that doubled as a bed. Nandu and I, being the senior-most, had the honour of getting these beds to sleep on. At about this time, our house at 53 Anand Park was ready and I saw no merit in staying in a hostel. After a bit of stubbornness on my part, my parents relented and I shifted there. A cook was employed to look after breakfast and dinner, and lunch was delivered at school through a 'tiffin' service. I stayed alone thus, often rustling up some egg curry and rice for dinner when Balu the cook would be unwell or on *chhutti* (holiday). This arrangement, though it made me quite independent, did not last long. I was in the final year of school with board exams less than a year away, so my mother moved down from Devlali to 'supervise' me. It was a relief to have her around, especially since Balu had limited culinary expertise.

Since my father was in Devlali, I would go there for the school holidays. My father's friend, Wing Commander GJ Singh, was also posted there and they were good friends. They had two sons, Karambir (KB) and Paramvir (Pampi); KB being of my age and Pampi a couple of years younger. There were other children too in the Air Force Station and we all used to play various games together. Cricket was, of course, our favourite. Since the playing field was opposite KB's house, we would all troop there for a 'drinks' break. KB's mother, Raji auntie as we called her, would get quite exasperated on account of having to fill the empty water bottles time and again. Once while playing on the driveway, a

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